the book, an exception has been made in the case of R.K. Talwar, who was two decades younger than Shroff and a decade younger than H.T. Parekh.

Book I deals with the career of Sir Sorabji Pochkhanawala and his founding of the Central Bank of India in 1911 in the face of much opposition. It describes the travails of the fledgling institution and how the Central Bank overcame these early challenges and reached a position of great eminence within a short span of twenty-five years. Sorabji resigned from the Bank of India where he had a secure job to embark on the extremely ambitious, and in the eyes of his family and friends, foolhardy venture, of setting up his own bank. Along the way, he managed to persuade Sir Pherozeshah Mehta to accept the Chairmanship of the bank. A number of banks failed in the closing decades of the nineteenth century and the opening decades of the twentieth century. The Central Bank of India too had its share of runs motivated by malice and a desire to see the swadeshi bank fail. But the Central Bank survived each crisis successfully, emerging stronger with each run.

The Central Bank also played ‘big brother’ to two institutions: the Union Bank of India and the TIB. The latter amalgamated with the Central Bank of India, an unprecedented event in Indian banking, made all the more remarkable by the fact that the Central was a much smaller bank than the one it intended to absorb. A man who had the vision and grit to establish a bank in the face of stiff opposition was hardly likely to lack in ideas and innovativeness. The innovations introduced by Sorabji included the Home Savings Safe, Three Year Cash Certificates, the Safe Deposit Vault, employing women assistants to serve lady customers, rupee travellers’ cheques, and many more. The Bank also broke new ground when it started administering estates on behalf of its clients. Sorabji was not just the founder of a bank; he was also concerned with the more general problems of Indian banking and was all for expansion of banking in rural areas. He was an expert witness before the Indian Central Banking Enquiry Committee (ICBEC) and was also appointed as the Chairman of the Ceylon Banking Commission. Inevitably, there are bound to be stresses and strains in an institution. The internal dissension in the bank, which came to be known as the Masani Affair (after Rustum Masani) was the sorriest chapter in its history. Sir Dinshaw Wacha, one of the Directors of the bank, felt that Sorabji was keeping the Board in the dark on many important issues. Sir